

I saw a sentence recently that said:

“Genuinely hope you get to experience a man who doesn’t equate his manhood to passing himself out to a community of women.”

And I understood the sentiment.

Then I laughed because, darling, have you met women?

We need to stop pretending this is exclusively a male disease.

There are women who have made being desired into a full time occupation.

Men do it.

Women do it.

Some people need romantic attention the way Safaricom needs you to buy another data bundle.

There must always be somebody.

A man in the DMs.

A woman texting.

An ex who still wants them.

A colleague who is “just being friendly.”

A gym crush.

A situationship.

A backup situationship for the situationship.

And someone they are not even remotely interested in, but they would still be mildly offended if that person stopped flirting with them.

That last one is important.

Because sometimes you do not want the person.

You want the knowledge that **you could have the person.**

There is an ego boost in knowing somebody would drop everything if you called.

I know this because I have experienced it.

I have enjoyed attention.

I still enjoy attention.

I am not going to sit here pretending I have never posted a picture knowing damn well I looked good and thinking, *let us see who has eyes today.*

Of course it feels good when somebody you find attractive tells you that you look beautiful.

Of course it is flattering when somebody wants you.

Of course there is a little satisfaction in knowing you can walk into a room and turn a few heads.

I am a woman, not a nun in a mountain monastery.

Attention can be fun.

The problem is when you start needing it.

There is a huge difference between **enjoying attention and depending on it.**

I had to learn that distinction myself.

At some point, the attention stopped being exciting.

Not because I suddenly became too evolved for compliments. Please. I enjoy being told I look good.

It became boring because I realised how repetitive it was.

Another "you are beautiful."

Another "what are you doing tonight?"

Another "I have been thinking about you."

Another man who has known me for approximately seventeen minutes telling me he has never met anyone like me.

Sir, you have not even learned my surname.

Relax.

Eventually, you start noticing how little some attention actually means.

A man can want you without knowing you.

A woman can want you without respecting you.

Someone can be obsessed with your body and completely uninterested in your mind.

Someone can text you every night and still have absolutely no intention of building anything with you.

Someone can call you gorgeous while simultaneously sending “hey stranger” to four other people.

So yes, congratulations.

You are wanted.

By whom?

For what?

And for how long?

Those are better questions.

Because there are people who have turned desirability into a competition.

They need to know how many people want them.

They tell their friends.

They show screenshots.

They mention the famous person who slid into their DMs.

They casually announce that someone wants to take them on holiday.

They tell you their ex is begging for them back.

They tell you three people asked for their number at the same event.

And you are sitting there thinking, *Okay, babe. Are we announcing election results?*

I have seen women do this.

I have seen men do this.

And I have participated in my own smaller versions of it.

Because sometimes attention feels like power.

Especially when you have experienced being ignored, rejected, underestimated or made to feel unattractive.

Suddenly, having people want you feels like revenge.

Oh, you didn't want me? Look at all these people who do.

That can feel incredible.

For about five minutes.

Then you realise you are still using other people's desire to settle an argument you have with yourself.

That is where it becomes pathetic.

And I mean that lovingly, because I have enough self awareness to include myself in the indictment.

There is something particularly exhausting about watching someone maintain ten romantic connections they do not actually care about because they are terrified of having none.

They are not building relationships.

They are maintaining evidence.

Evidence that they are desirable.

Evidence that they are not alone.

Evidence that if their current person leaves, there will be another one.

It becomes a personal insurance policy.

"I have options."

Okay.

But do you have standards?

Because those two things are not interchangeable.

You can have twenty options and terrible judgment.

You can have nobody pursuing you and excellent judgment.

One of those is far more useful when life gets serious.

And let us talk about the woman who says, "I don't even like him, but I like the attention."

At least she is honest.

That sentence is actually more revealing than she realises.

Because now we know the man is not the prize.

The attention is.

She likes the feeling of being wanted.

She likes knowing she can text him and he will answer.

She likes posting something and knowing he will react.

She likes watching him become jealous.

She likes having someone available.

And if he suddenly gets a girlfriend?

Now she is irritated.

Ma'am.

You did not want the man.

You wanted his attention.

Let him go.

The same applies to men.

You do not need six women you have no intention of committing to.

You do not need to keep flirting with somebody because you enjoy knowing she still likes you.

You do not need to collect women like you are building a football squad.

And having a girlfriend does not become more masculine because three other women are secretly interested in you.

That is not masculinity.

That is insecurity wearing a nice shirt.

Women are capable of the same nonsense.

A woman does not become more feminine because five men want her.

She does not become more valuable because somebody is willing to spend money on her.

She does not become more beautiful because strangers are commenting fire emojis under her picture.

And she certainly does not become more powerful because she can make a man jealous.

You know what is actually powerful?

Being able to receive attention without becoming dependent on it.

Being able to say, "Yes, I know he likes me. No, I do not want him."

Being able to recognise that somebody finds you attractive without turning that information into a relationship.

Being able to enjoy flirting without needing it to become validation.

Being able to lose someone's interest without immediately wondering what happened to your worth.

That last one took me time.

Because when you are accustomed to attention, losing it can feel strangely personal.

You start wondering whether you have changed.

Whether you look different.

Whether you said something wrong.

Whether they found somebody prettier.

Whether you are suddenly less interesting.

Sometimes the answer is much less dramatic.

They lost interest.

People do.

It happens.

Your worth did not fall by 30 percent because somebody stopped texting you.

Please.

We have got to stop giving random people that kind of authority over our self esteem.

And I think I have reached a point where some attention genuinely bores me.

Not all of it.

I am still a woman with eyes and a functioning ego.

But there are forms of attention that no longer impress me.

A man wanting to sleep with me tells me very little.

A woman wanting to sleep with a man tells her very little about his character.

Someone saying, "You are so beautiful," is nice.

Someone remembering something I said three weeks ago is more interesting.

Someone wanting access to my body is ordinary.

Someone wanting to understand my mind is different.

Someone being attracted to me is flattering.

Someone having the discipline to treat me well when attraction is no longer new is what I actually pay attention to.

That is the upgrade.

At some point, you stop asking:

Who wants me?

And start asking:

Who do I actually want?

Who do I respect?

Who makes my life better?

Who has character?

Who is emotionally safe?

Who has something going on upstairs?

Who can have a disagreement without behaving like a disgruntled toddler?

Who can keep their word?

Who has a life outside of chasing people?

Who do I genuinely enjoy?

Because “everyone wants me” is not an achievement if you do not want any of them.

And “I have options” means very little if your options are terrible.

There is also something deeply unserious about needing to constantly prove that you can attract people.

Attracting somebody is not particularly difficult.

People are lonely.

People are curious.

People are horny.

People like pretty faces.

People like attention.

People like being wanted.

The bar is on the floor.

The interesting part is what happens after the attraction.

Can you sustain something?

Can you communicate?

Can you be honest?

Can you choose one person when ten people are available?

Can you walk away from attention that you know you should not entertain?

Can you sit alone without frantically searching for another person to make you feel significant?

That is where adulthood begins.

Because eventually, the thrill of being wanted wears off.

The DMs become repetitive.

The compliments blur together.

The dating apps start looking like the same six faces wearing different shirts.

The “good morning beautiful” messages become background noise.

And you realise you were collecting attention from people you did not even particularly like.

For what?

A dopamine hit?

An ego massage?

Something to screenshot for the group chat?

There is nothing wrong with enjoying being desired.

I think pretending otherwise is dishonest.

Sometimes it is fun.

Sometimes it is sexy.

Sometimes you want to know that you still have it.

Fine.

Have your little moment.

Post the picture.

Enjoy the compliment.

Smile when the attractive person looks at you.

Let yourself feel pretty.

Then go home and remember that none of these people are responsible for telling you who you are.

Because the moment you need the attention to feel valuable, you are no longer enjoying it.

It is consuming you.

And that is when being wanted stops being a nice part of your life and becomes your entire personality.

I would rather be someone who knows she can be desired and does not need to prove it every Tuesday.

I would rather choose carefully than be chosen constantly.

I would rather have one person who genuinely sees me than twenty people who simply like what they see.

And honestly?

Sometimes I would rather be left alone.

The older I get, the more I understand that peace is underrated.

There is a peculiar freedom in not needing to be chased.

You stop performing.

You stop checking.

You stop calculating.

You stop wondering who viewed the story.

You stop keeping people around because their attention makes you feel pretty.

You become harder to impress.

And strangely enough, much easier to please.

Because now somebody does not have to convince you that you are desirable.

They have to give you a reason to care.

That is a completely different game.